

Although working in fashion set me on a path of undisciplined spending, I am grateful for it opening many doors in my career. The turning point was becoming a real estate journalist and understanding the security a property provides. Until then, I had lived week to week. I had so many clothes; most were in storage, sorted by season. I have since held several market stalls, and pumped the cash back into paying down what I owed on a credit card, which I cut up. And I am now debt free, have better financial habits and a changed attitude to money.

Sometimes I am sickened by my own wastage but, in the moment, I enjoyed my excess. I'm ready to tighten my belt – which is no longer a designer one, but one more suited to my slimmed-down budget.

I had also figured that I'd eventually meet a man and together we'd scrimp for a deposit for our own home. Feminists will be appalled by that confession, but all my life, the concept of home ownership had been presented to me as a joint venture – by banks, magazines, family and friends. A man is not a financial plan, but it was natural to assume I'd not be embarking on my first property purchase on my own.

On relationships, I will say that dating costs a bomb. I don't seem to be doing much of it lately, for better or worse, so finding the money to regularly hit the town with a potential paramour hasn't been a worry. Besides, the right guy will be happy with home-cooked fare, instead of a table for two at a fancy restaurant. At least, until I have inked the contract for my first home – and then we'll celebrate, fancy restaurant and all.

I recommend nominating a financial gatekeeper if, like me, you have poor self-control. When I report on auctions and first home buyers say they have had financial help from their parents, by a gifted deposit, I am envious. However, in a way, I am also getting financial help from my folks, in the form of forced frugality. It has been an education.

And that dream of buying my own art deco apartment, which I will renovate, is inching closer with each pay packet, even if I don't know how much I have saved. If I am unaware of the balance, I can't get distracted by thinking of all the clothes I could buy. And this way, the apartment dream is in clear sight.

The response